

KERSTIN JOENSSON/AFP



In early February, Mohammad Arif Khan will be making his Winter Olympic debut in Beijing. But even before he steps out on the course, he has made history as the first Indian to have qualified for two events at the quadrennial event—the slalom and the giant slalom disciplines of alpine skiing. It's a sport that features athletes rushing down a snow slope at breakneck speeds of over 70 kmph, while twisting past flags en route to the finish line. Each run is about shedding infinitesimal fractions of time and each run comes down to the performance of your body's every muscle, sinew and twitch.

So, alongside the physical aspects of training, Khan, 31, has also been spending much time tuning his mind these days. "Speed is everything as you rush downhill while at the same time trying to maintain the right movements to stay in line and take on the turns. To pull it off, you have to be very strong mentally, really brave. If you are brave enough, the rest of the things simply fall in place," he says. Khan knows a thing or two about being fearless in the face of adversity. It is what has allowed him to pursue the sport over the past 15 years or so. And most times, against all odds.

Khan wore his first pair of skis at the age of four. The early days were all fun and games, as he spent most of his time at his father's ski shop, one that caters to the influx of winter tourists in Gulmarg. After excelling at local competitions, he made his mark at the national level as a teenager. It was when he looked to further hone his skills that Khan realised just what he was up against. "There was no support or sponsorship because nobody believed in the sport. Ever since, my father would set aside money from the skiing business so that I could pursue skiing. Good tourism meant good money," he says.

Even back then, the dream was to race at the Winter Olympics. However, the regular shutdowns in Kashmir constantly afflicted his training. Besides, skiing is an expensive sport. There were certain years when there were no earnings, let alone profits. Khan supplemented his training on the local slopes with his meagre savings as a ski guide, though travelling for competitions was often out of the question. With few avenues to make a living, his father Yaseen—also his biggest supporter—often felt that a lack of resources would deny his son the opportunity to compete on the world stage. "To be mentally stable to perform in sports was a little bit harder. It's difficult even now. But I continued dreaming because I knew it would happen. I just had to be a little more patient," Khan says.

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By 2006, Khan started competing internationally as a junior, putting together every resource at his disposal. He started making connections to train abroad, often at subsidised rates. He even managed to race at four FIS World Ski Championships. The Olympics, however, continued to elude him. He was ruled out of the 2014 edition due to an injury. Four years later, a defunct national body meant that most of his efforts were focused on fundraising. Crowdfunding allowed him to race at a few qualifying events, but he eventually fell short of funds and his Olympic dream continued to hang in the balance. "Missing out on those two Olympics was a good lesson for me to prepare early